are no jobs as we saw during the Covid pandemic," says Nikhil Dey, founder-member of Soochna Evam Rozgar Adhikaar Abhiyan, a citizens' movement for transparency in governance.

At times, Gehlot takes central schemes and expands the base and scale. The Chiranjeevi health insurance scheme, for one, offers coverage of up to Rs 25 lakh for inpatients in all state-run and several private hospitals. Some 14.1 million families have registered, most for free. The remaining (about a million)—earning above Rs 8 lakh annually—have to shell out only Rs 850 per annum from next year. So, with a Rs 2,732 crore premium paid per annum to insurers, Rajasthan has been able to provide almost cashless treatment in most hospitals in the state. OPDs are entirely free as are most medicines and tests in all government hospitals. In contrast, the Centre's Ayushman Bharat only covers expenses up to Rs 5 lakh for inpatients for the BPL category.

There's more than a grain of truth to the BJP's charge that Gehlot's primary intent to further his chances in the polls. But will that happen? Not a guaranteed outcome. Rajasthan is notorious for voting out incumbent regimes—Gehlot himself has lost twice as CM, in 2003 and 2013, by massive margins. C-Voter surveys indicate that if the election was to happen right now, the Congress could get around 88 seats, just 13 short of a simple majority in the 200-seat House. Gehlot may hope one last push may take him across the line. "I have brought in new schemes from the very first day of this term," says the three-time CM. "In my previous two tenures, some schemes were launched late and others did not reach the needy. That's why we had outreach programmes so everyone knows what they are entitled to," he tells INDIA TODAY. The 'inflation relief camps' set up in May have so far distributed 76.4 million 'guarantee cards' listing their entitlements to beneficiaries—18.1 million families have registered—though the BJP has been furious about the profusion of Congress leaders gracing these events.

Ex-CM and BJP leader Vasundhara Raje thinks people are wise to pre-poll 'schemes'. "Very often Gehlot relaunches old schemes introduced during our tenure," she says. Gehlot, in turn, has been warning voters that they must "vote for us to ensure the welfare schemes continue," adding that the BJP will close them down if they come to power. Raje refutes this, saying this never happens with good work—only "flop schemes are reviewed". The BJP also accuses Gehlot of pushing the state into bankruptcy with his flurry of welfarist measures that soon shade off into outright freebies. Think only of his other big bang steps: restoring the old pension scheme; free electricity up to 100 units per month and 2,000 free units per month for some 1.1 million farmers (entailing a power subsidy bill of over Rs 24,000 crore); free smartphones with internet data (Rs 6,800 each) to all women of the state.



"VERY OFTEN GEHLOT RELAUNCHES OLD SCHEMES THAT WERE INTRODUCED DURING OUR TENURE"

VASUNDHARA RAJE
Ex-CM and BJP leader

The CM, in turn, cites figures to claim his fiscal management is prudent enough. "We have been restructuring debt up to the admissible limit prescribed by the Finance Commission. Our fiscal deficits during FY22 and FY23 were 3.96 per cent and 3.50 per cent of the GSDP, respectively, against the permissible limits of 5.15 per cent and 4.35 per cent," Gehlot says. He calls the Centre's attitude towards limiting the states' debts unfair. "Rajasthan's debt-to-GSDP ratio for 2023-24 is estimated at 36.8 per cent, compared to the Centre's 56.2 per cent, which is 150 per cent higher," he claims. The state's net borrowings for the same period are estimated at almost 4 per cent of the GSDP, whereas it's 5.6 per cent for the Centre. Gehlot also points out that in 2013-14—the terminal year of his second tenure—the debt-to-GSDP ratio was 23.6 per cent which grew to 34.2 per cent (a rise of 45 per cent) by the end of the BJP's tenure in 2018-19. "But the ratio has risen only by 7.17 per cent in our government so far," he says. "The point I am making is that we have maintained fiscal discipline rather well, contrary to the perception the BJP tries to build up."

Rajasthan is also a high spender on what Gehlot calls "human capital formation". Its outlays on education (16.7 per cent), health (6.2 per cent) and social sector (67 per cent) ride well above the national averages. "This has helped us increase GSDP by 19.5 per cent in 2020-21 and 16 per cent in 2021-22, and per capita by 18.10 per cent in 2021-22, both India's fourth highest," says the CM. As a consequence, the state's tax mop-up has increased—24 per cent and 17 per cent in FY22 and FY23, respectively.

Gehlot also has other tricks up his sleeve. To buy affections in a fragmented caste landscape, his government has set up 17 boards for different communities, including the Maharana Pratap Board for Rajputs, Veer Teja Ji Kisan Kalyan Board for Jats etc. In a dramatic move, his regime also carved out 17 new districts, taking the total number to 50. Will all this work? At least on a handful of legislations, seen over the long term, whether they benefit Gehlot in December or not may remain a side note of history. ■